

SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Religious Experience: Nature and Object - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC Philosophy Optional | Paper II, Section B | 32 diagnostics, 8 solved PYQs and 6 original Mains models

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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Religious Experience: Nature and Object - Solved Practice Workbook

Philosophy Optional · Philosophy Paper II - Philosophy of Religion · Topic 06 A standalone practice document. It is designed to be worked without the learning session open beside it, and it repeats no teaching prose.

How to use this workbook

Attempt every item before reading its key. The correct option position was fixed **independently for each question** using a length-balanced, non-patterned assignment: there is no rotation, no repeating cycle and no adjacent repetition to exploit, and each of the four positions carries exactly eight answers across the thirty-two diagnostics. Every option carries a question-specific explanation, and every question carries a unique examiner trap. The previous-year questions reproduce the official printed wording exactly; **the model answers are independent learner practice and are never official UPSC keys.**

What is inside

Part	Content	Count
1	Core diagnostic MCQs	24
2	Remedial diagnostic MCQs	8
-	Question-specific option explanations	128
-	Unique examiner traps	32
3	Verified previous-year questions, fully solved	8
4	Original solved Mains models (2 x 10, 2 x 15, 2 x 20)	6

Marking and timing conventions

- Word bands: 10 marks ≈ 150 words · 15 marks ≈ 250 words · 20 marks ≈ 350 words.
- Every model answer follows **claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification**.
- Every model answer closes with a decided verdict, and the twenty-mark models additionally name the **defeater** that would change that verdict.
- **Standing penalties in this clause:** an ungraded four-mark list; an unanswered second deliverable; a verdict that summarises instead of deciding; and any invented year for Schleiermacher, Swinburne, Hick, Forman or Teresa.

Terminology rule

English-first throughout. The English concept leads; the accurate Sanskrit, Pali, Latin or German term follows in parentheses.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Practice protocol

Attempt every item before reading its key. The correct option position was fixed **independently for each question** using a length-balanced, non-patterned assignment: there is no rotation, no repeating cycle and no adjacent repetition to exploit, and the four positions each carry exactly eight answers across the thirty-two diagnostics. Every option carries a question-specific explanation, and every question carries a unique examiner trap.

CORE DIAGNOSTIC MCQS - 24

MCQ 1. The four analytical layers, and the jump that is illegitimate

A candidate writes: "The experience was overwhelming and life-changing, so its object must be real." Which analytical failure does this best illustrate?

- A. It confuses doctrinal authenticity with psychological genuineness, since the tradition's own recognition test has not yet been consulted at all.
- B. It denies mediation, since a state of that intensity could not have been shaped by the concepts and expectations the subject already possessed.
- C. It confuses interpretation with claimed object, since the tradition's naming of the ultimate has simply been read back into what was presented.
- D. It jumps from phenomenology directly to epistemic force, since the felt intensity of the state is being treated by itself as warrant for its claimed object.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this names a real distinction, but the candidate's sentence says nothing about conformity to a tradition; the fault is in the inference from felt intensity, not in a missing doctrinal test.
- **B:** Incorrect: nothing in the sentence denies mediation; it could be granted entirely and the inference from intensity to reality would still be invalid.
- **C:** Incorrect: that describes the naming-to-meeting jump, in which a tradition's vocabulary is treated as identifying the object; here the premise offered is intensity, not vocabulary.
- **D:** Correct: layer one is what the experience is like and layer four is what it justifies, and "overwhelming, therefore real" moves from the first to the fourth without passing through claimed object or interpretation.

Examiner trap 1: Scripts that begin with a vivid narration of a mystical episode almost always commit this jump in their second paragraph; open instead by naming which of the four layers the stem is buying.

MCQ 2. Which marks entitle a state to be called mystical

In *The Varieties of Religious Experience*, which pair does James treat as jointly sufficient to entitle a state to be called mystical?

- A. Transiency and passivity, since brevity and receptivity are the two features that separate a mystical state from ordinary discursive reasoning.
- B. Ineffability and noetic quality, since defiance of adequate expression and presented insight together settle the classification.
- C. Passivity and noetic quality, since being grasped by a superior power is what marks a genuine disclosure.
- D. Ineffability and transiency, since a state that could be adequately stated, or sustained at will, would be an ordinary episode of cognition.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: these are the two marks James describes as "less sharply marked" and merely usual; promoting them to definitional status is exactly the error his grading is designed to prevent.
- **B:** Correct: James's own grading makes ineffability, "the handiest" mark, and noetic quality, insight into depths of truth unplumbed by the discursive intellect, the two marks that entitle a state to the name.
- **C:** Incorrect: it pairs one defining mark with one usual mark, which reproduces the flat-list error in a subtler form and would exclude states that are not felt as passive.
- **D:** Incorrect: transiency is a usual accompaniment, not a criterion, and treating brevity as definitional would disqualify stable realisation from the category altogether.

Examiner trap 2: The flat four-mark list is the single commonest error in this clause; write the two-plus-two grading in the first body paragraph of any James answer.

MCQ 3. What James's grading makes possible

Why does the grading of James's marks matter for the Indian-Western comparison?

- A. Because transiency is only a usual mark, a stable and established liberating knowledge (*jñāna*) can still count as a mystical state.
- B. Because passivity is definitional, only those experiences produced entirely by grace, with no preparatory discipline at all, count as mystical states.
- C. Because ineffability is only usual, traditions that describe their highest experiences in elaborate technical detail remain fully classifiable as mystical.
- D. Because noetic quality is only usual, an experience carrying no sense of insight or disclosure whatever can still be classified as a mystical state.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: since duration is a statistical accompaniment rather than a criterion, Advaitic *jñāna* - settled knowledge rather than an episode - is not disqualified, and the comparison the paper rewards becomes possible.
- **B:** Incorrect: passivity is one of the two usual marks, and James expressly allows that voluntary preliminary operations may facilitate the onset.
- **C:** Incorrect: ineffability is one of the two defining marks, so the option inverts James's grading and would make the classification depend on descriptive richness.
- **D:** Incorrect: noetic quality is the second defining mark, and removing it would leave a mere feeling with no claim to disclosure at all.

Examiner trap 3: Candidates who list four equal marks have, without noticing, defined the Indian case out of the mystical category and then cannot run the comparison the question wants.

MCQ 4. Medical materialism and the maxim about fruits

Which statement about James's method is accurate?

- A. He coined the maxim about fruits himself and then used medical materialism as his working test of religious authenticity in the case histories.
- B. He rejects medical materialism as a fallacy about origins and adopts the scriptural maxim about fruits as the criterion in its place.
- C. He accepts medical materialism for the clearly pathological cases and rejects the appeal to fruits on the ground that it is pragmatically circular.
- D. He treats medical materialism as a method of discernment and derives the maxim about fruits from his own psychology.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: it reverses both attributions - the maxim is Matthew 7:16/20, which James adopts, and medical materialism is the fallacy he names in order to reject it.
- **B:** Correct: medical materialism is James's own term in Lecture I for discrediting a state by its physiological or pathological origin, and the biblical maxim is the consequential criterion he adopts in its place.
- **C:** Incorrect: James makes no such concession, and the appeal to fruits is precisely the test he retains after refusing origin-based dismissal.
- **D:** Incorrect: medical materialism is a fallacy for James, not a procedure, and the maxim is scriptural rather than a product of his psychology.

Examiner trap 4: Attributing "by their fruits ye shall know them" to James rather than to Matthew is a small error that a well-read examiner reads as a large one.

MCQ 5. The second deliverable of the 2022 stem

The 2022 stem asks for the nature *and variety* of religious experiences as presented by James. Which set correctly supplies the "variety" half?

- A. Extrovertive and introvertive mysticism, together with the five phenomenological marks that are shared between the two types.
- B. Nature mysticism, monistic mysticism and theistic mysticism, ranked in ascending order of completeness and adequacy.
- C. Healthy-mindedness and the sick soul, the divided self resolved in conversion, saintliness as durable fruits, and mysticism.
- D. Propositional revelation, non-propositional revelation, and the faithful experiencing-as of a religiously ambiguous event.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this is Stace's classification from *Mysticism and Philosophy*, not James's survey of the forms of personal religion.
- **B:** Incorrect: this is Zaehner's threefold scheme with its contested ranking, and attributing it to James confuses two authors writing half a century apart.
- **C:** Correct: these are the varieties of personal religion James actually studies - two temperaments before evil, the divided self resolved by conversion, the durable fruits of saintliness, and the experiential pole of mysticism.
- **D:** Incorrect: this belongs to the analysis of revelation and derives from Hick's model, not from James's psychological survey.

Examiner trap 5: A script that answers 2022 with the four marks alone has completed one of two printed deliverables and has capped its own marks.

MCQ 6. The anatomy of the numinous

Which reading of *mysterium tremendum et fascinans* is correct?

- A. Wholly other and incommensurable with ordinary categories, at once overpowering in its majesty and irresistibly attractive.
- B. Mysterious in its origin, terrifying in the moral demand it imposes, and delightful in the reward that it holds out to the obedient.
- C. Unknown for the present, dreadful in the judgement it pronounces, and fascinating precisely because it can never in principle be understood.
- D. Incomprehensible by definition, frightening to the ignorant and the unprepared, and pleasing only to those who have already been made holy.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: Otto's three components are the mystery of the wholly other, the *tremendum* of awefulness, overpoweringness and energy, and the *fascinans* that attracts even while it terrifies.
- **B:** Incorrect: it moralises the *tremendum* into a demand and the *fascinans* into a reward, which is exactly the rational-ethical schematisation Otto says comes *after* the numinous datum.
- **C:** Incorrect: the *mysterium* is not merely what is not yet known but what is incommensurable with ordinary categories, and permanent unintelligibility is not what *fascinans* names.
- **D:** Incorrect: it distributes dread and attraction across two different classes of person, whereas Otto's point is that both are present in one state, in one subject, at once.

Examiner trap 6: Write the Latin in full once and then translate it; a script that uses the phrase without unpacking all three components has quoted rather than explained.

MCQ 7. Non-rational, schematisation, and the Schleiermacher comparison

Which statement about Otto is most accurate?

- A. The numinous is irrational, so moral and rational predicates contradict it and must be dropped from theology altogether as category mistakes.
- B. The numinous is identical with Schleiermacher's feeling of absolute dependence, restated in Latin vocabulary for a twentieth-century readership.
- C. The numinous is non-rational - not reducible to conceptual or moral judgement - and is later schematised by rational and ethical concepts alike.
- D. The numinous is a rational intuition of perfect goodness from which the accompanying feelings of awe and fascination are subsequently derived.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Otto claims non-rationality and denies irrationality, and he retains moral and rational predicates as later schematisations rather than discarding them.
- **B:** Incorrect: dependence characterises the subject's own condition, whereas the numinous is constituted by its directedness to a wholly other; Otto's account is usually read as a correction of Schleiermacher, not a translation of him.
- **C:** Correct: non-rational means not exhausted by conceptual-moral judgement, and Otto holds that rational and ethical predicates are applied to the holy afterwards, in schematisation.
- **D:** Incorrect: it inverts the order of Otto's analysis by making the moral intuition primary and the numinous derivative, which is the position he wrote *The Idea of the Holy* to refute.

Examiner trap 7: Glossing "non-rational" as "irrational" converts Otto's central claim into one he explicitly denies, and examiners treat it as a comprehension failure rather than a slip.

MCQ 8. Stace's introvertive type and his methodological move

Which description of Stace's position is correct?

- A. Introvertive mysticism perceives the One shining through the many, while extrovertive mysticism excludes all sensory and conceptual content whatever.
- B. Both types are equally complete, and Stace declines to rank them at all on the ground that any ranking would be confessionally motivated.
- C. The two types share no phenomenological marks, and whatever unity they have is asserted at the level of doctrine rather than of experience.
- D. Introvertive mysticism excludes all sensory and conceptual content, leaving a unitary contentless consciousness that Stace treats as the higher type.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the descriptions are transposed - perceiving the One through the multiplicity of sensed objects is the extrovertive type, not the introvertive.
- **B:** Incorrect: Stace does rank, treating introvertive mysticism as the higher and more complete type; the confessional-ranking charge is levelled at Zaehner.
- **C:** Incorrect: Stace's whole argument depends on shared marks - objectivity, blessedness, holiness, paradoxicality and ineffability - reported within the descriptions themselves.
- **D:** Correct: the introvertive type is defined by the exclusion of sensory and conceptual content, and Stace's separation of experience from interpretation then grounds the common-core thesis.

Examiner trap 8: The extrovertive and introvertive labels are frequently transposed under time pressure; anchor them by remembering that extrovertive looks *outward* through the senses.

MCQ 9. Zaehner's typology and how to handle his ranking

Which treatment of Zaehner is defensible?

- A. Retain the ranking, since theistic mysticism preserves the creature-creator distinction and is on that ground the more complete and adequate type.
- B. Reject the whole scheme, since a classification produced by a religious convert with a confessional commitment can carry no philosophical content.
- C. Retain the nature, monistic and theistic classification while dropping the ranking, since monistic and theistic reports genuinely differ in logical form.
- D. Merge his three types with Stace's two, since taken together they yield a comprehensive fivefold classification of the varieties of mystical state.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: preserving a distinction is a structural feature, not a measure of completeness, and the ranking is the element most widely criticised as confessionally motivated.
- **B:** Incorrect: this is a genetic fallacy of the same shape James condemned as medical materialism, and it discards a classification that does real comparative work.
- **C:** Correct: the classification survives the criticism because identity-reports and relation-reports differ in logical form, and a common-core theory owes an explanation of that difference.
- **D:** Incorrect: the two schemes are rivals answering opposite questions about a common core, so adding them together produces confusion rather than a fivefold typology.

Examiner trap 9: Merging Stace and Zaehner into one "typology of mysticism" destroys the very disagreement the topic exists to examine.

MCQ 10. Katz, Forman and where the dispute is decided

Which statement about the constructivism debate is accurate?

- A. Katz holds that there are no unmediated experiences at all, and Forman's Pure Consciousness Event contests that thesis at the contentless limit.
- B. Katz holds that all mystics undergo one and the same experience, and Forman argues that they undergo many experiences that are differently described.
- C. Forman holds that tradition constitutes the experience itself, and Katz replies that a contentless state refutes that claim.
- D. Both hold that mediation makes mystical reports fabrications, and they differ only over which traditions are most heavily implicated in the fabrication.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: Katz's 1978 thesis makes tradition, expectation and practice constitutive of the experience, and Forman's contentless state is offered as the one case that offers nothing for concepts to shape.
- **B:** Incorrect: it reverses the positions, assigning the common-core thesis to the constructivist and constructivism to his critic.
- **C:** Incorrect: the names are transposed; Forman is the defender of the contentless case, not the proponent of constitution by tradition.
- **D:** Incorrect: neither concludes that mediation entails fabrication, and mediated perception is still perception, which is precisely why the debate concerns an inference rather than the reports.

Examiner trap 10: Constructivism attacks the *inference* from cross-cultural similarity to a shared object; treating it as a proof that mystical experience is invented overstates it in a way the examiner will mark down.

MCQ 11. The structure of Advaitic realisation

Which formulation states the main structural feature of Advaitic religious experience?

- A. A purified subject perceives Brahman as a supremely subtle object presented to the inner sense after long preparatory discipline.
- B. A devotee enters into loving union with Brahman while the distinction between worshipper and worshipped is carefully preserved throughout.
- C. A meditator isolates consciousness from materiality, so that the self remains alone, unrelated and free of every further modification.
- D. Subject-object duality collapses in a non-dual recognition in which the realiser *is* Brahman.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: describing the realisation as a subject perceiving Brahman as an object is precisely the error the doctrine of self-luminosity is designed to exclude.
- **B:** Incorrect: preserved distinction in loving union is Rāmānuja's Viśiṣṭādvaita and Zaehner's theistic type, not Śaṅkara's non-dualism.
- **C:** Incorrect: the isolation of consciousness from matter is Sāṃkhya-Yoga's aloneness (*kaivalya*), a different structure with a different terminus.
- **D:** Correct: the non-dual (*nirvikalpa*) recognition abolishes the subject-object structure, which is why "I am Brahman" states an identity rather than a relation.

Examiner trap 11: Any sentence of the form "experience of Brahman" invites the objection that Advaita has been dualised; prefer "recognition that the self is Brahman".

MCQ 12. The correct technical use of *anirvacanīya*

In Advaita's technical vocabulary, *anirvacanīya* is properly predicated of which of the following?

- A. *Māyā* and the world-appearance, as indescribable in the terms of either reality or unreality alike.
- B. Brahman itself, understood as the one reality from which all words turn back without ever having grasped what they were reaching for.
- C. The liberating realisation itself, understood as a state whose quality cannot be conveyed to anyone who has not already undergone it.
- D. The qualified Lord, understood as a form that is neither straightforwardly identical with Brahman nor straightforwardly different from Brahman.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the term marks the status of *māyā* and the world-appearance as distinct from both the real and the unreal (*sad-asad-vilakṣaṇa*), which is its settled technical use.
- **B:** Incorrect: Brahman's inexpressibility is carried by different vocabulary - beyond objectifying speech (*avācya*), "from which words turn back" - and using *anirvacanīya* here is the scripted error.
- **C:** Incorrect: that is James's ineffability transposed into Sanskrit; the realisation's incommunicability is not what the technical term denotes.
- **D:** Incorrect: the qualified Lord's status is handled by other categories, and the option quietly imports a distinct doctrinal dispute.

Examiner trap 12: A 2025 Religious Language question prints *anirvacanīyatā* in its correct sense; importing it into an Advaita experience answer shows an examiner exactly where the reading stopped.

MCQ 13. Radhakrishnan's inversion

Which statement best represents Radhakrishnan's position in *The Hindu View of Life*?

- A. Creeds generate the very experiences that later appear to confirm them, so doctrine is epistemically prior to intuition in every developed religion.
- B. Direct spiritual experience of the Real is primary and self-certifying, while dogma, creed and ritual are secondary interpretations of that experience.
- C. Religious intuition is a private feeling with no cognitive content at all, so the resulting tolerance follows simply from mutual ignorance of the Real.
- D. Institutional religion is the only reliable route to intuition, which cannot be reached by individual discipline outside an established community.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: it reverses the inversion that defines his position, in which experience generates doctrine rather than being generated by it.
- **B:** Correct: religion is grounded in direct, intuitive experience of the Real, which is self-certifying and claimed universal, with creed and ritual as secondary interpretations.
- **C:** Incorrect: integral intuition is explicitly a mode of *knowing* that unites cognition, feeling and will, and his tolerance rests on a shared depth, not on shared ignorance.
- **D:** Incorrect: it makes institutions primary, which is the position his account subordinates to experience.

Examiner trap 13: In a stem that names *The Hindu View of Life*, generic "Indian spirituality" content scores poorly; name the work's own theses before evaluating them.

MCQ 14. "In the light of the Vedāntic tradition"

Why is it a mistake to answer a Vedāntic-experience stem with Advaita alone?

- A. Because Advaita denies that religious experience occurs at all, so another school in the tradition must supply the account.
- B. Because the Vedāntic schools agree entirely on the structure of the experience and differ only over the technical vocabulary that each of them prefers.
- C. Because Advaita is a comparatively later development and therefore cannot be taken to represent the classical position of the tradition as a whole.
- D. Because Rāmānuja and Madhva belong to the tradition and report relation rather than identity, so the tradition contains both of the structures.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Advaita's entire soteriology culminates in direct realisation, so it plainly affirms rather than denies that such experience occurs.
- **B:** Incorrect: the disagreement is structural, since Viśiṣṭādvaita and Dvaita preserve the worshipper whom Advaita's identity-claim dissolves.
- **C:** Incorrect: the chronological claim is neither accurate as stated nor the reason the reduction fails; the reason is internal plurality.
- **D:** Correct: Viśiṣṭādvaita makes selves and world real modes dependent on a personal Brahman and Dvaita hardens the difference further, so "the tradition" contains identity-recognition and intentional encounter together.

Examiner trap 14: The printed word is "tradition", not "Advaita"; reducing the one to the other forfeits the internal comparison that the stem is designed to elicit.

MCQ 15. Four Indian structures and their termini

Which pairing of tradition and claimed terminus is correct throughout?

- A. Advaita - a personal Lord; Yoga - Brahman as the self; devotion - cessation; Buddhism - isolated consciousness alone.
- B. Advaita - the self as Brahman; Yoga - isolated consciousness; devotion - a personal Lord; Buddhism - cessation.
- C. Advaita - cessation; Yoga - a personal Lord; devotion - isolated consciousness; Buddhism - the self as Brahman throughout.
- D. Advaita - isolated consciousness; Yoga - cessation; devotion - the self as Brahman; Buddhism - a personal creator Lord.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: every pairing is displaced, and giving Buddhism the isolation of consciousness attributes a Sāṃkhya-Yoga terminus to a tradition that denies a permanent self.
- **B:** Correct: Advaita's terminus is the self as Brahman, Yoga's is isolated consciousness (*puruṣa*), devotion's is a personal Lord, and Buddhism's is Dharma and cessation (*nirvāṇa*) rather than a creator.
- **C:** Incorrect: assigning cessation to Advaita and Brahman to Buddhism inverts the two traditions whose difference the comparison most needs.
- **D:** Incorrect: it gives Buddhism a personal Lord, which contradicts the standard control that its terminus is not encounter with a creator God.

Examiner trap 15: Writing "Indian mysticism" as a single position is the Indian counterpart of the flat four-mark error; name the structure and the terminus.

MCQ 16. The genus and the species in the 2018 stem

What is the defensible answer to whether one can have God as the object of religion?

- A. No, because the sacred is purely a social classification whereas God is a phenomenological quality disclosed only in numinous awe.
- B. Yes without qualification, since every religion in fact directs its worship toward some supreme personal being under one description or another.
- C. Yes for theistic traditions, in which God is the source and the measure of all holiness, but not as a generic definition of religion.
- D. No, because the non-theistic traditions are more numerous than the theistic ones and their categories should therefore prevail in any definition.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: it misassigns the two analyses, since the social classification is Durkheim's sacred and the phenomenological quality is Otto's holy, and neither yields a flat negative.
- **B:** Incorrect: it is falsified by Buddhism, Jainism and Mīmāṃsā, which sustain a sacred without a responsive personal deity.
- **C:** Correct: God is the paradigm species for theistic traditions and the source and measure of everything else held holy, while a God-centred *definition* would stipulate whole religions out of the category.
- **D:** Incorrect: the argument is conceptual rather than statistical, and counting traditions is not how the adequacy of a definition is decided.

Examiner trap 16: The stem grants the generic category and asks about the specific one, so a flat yes or no answers a question that was not printed.

MCQ 17. Otto's holy against Durkheim's sacred

Which statement expresses the discriminating difference correctly?

- A. Otto's holy is defined by the prohibitions that separate it from the profane, whereas Durkheim's sacred is a quality disclosed to the subject in numinous awe.
- B. Otto's holy is a phenomenological quality of an object disclosed in awe, while Durkheim's sacred is a social classification defined by separation from the profane.
- C. Both are social classifications, differing only over whether the community doing the classifying is a tribal one or a modern industrial one.
- D. Both are phenomenological qualities of the object, differing only over whether it is dread or fascination that predominates in the resulting state.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the two accounts have been transposed, since prohibition and separation are Durkheim's apparatus and numinous disclosure is Otto's.
- **B:** Correct: Otto analyses how an object appears in awe, whereas Durkheim analyses how a community sets something apart, and treating them as one word misses the strongest objection to each.
- **C:** Incorrect: it erases Otto's phenomenology entirely and turns his central category into sociology.
- **D:** Incorrect: it erases Durkheim's functional definition, which is precisely the account that requires no deity at all.

Examiner trap 17: This is the highest-yield discriminator in the 2018 module; a script that uses "sacred" and "holy" interchangeably has forfeited it.

MCQ 18. Credulity, testimony and the serious defeater

Which statement is the most defensible summary of the veridicality debate?

- A. The principle of credulity establishes the object publicly, since a seeming is evidence for everyone who hears of it and not merely for the subject.
- B. Neuroscience is the decisive defeater, since a state possessing an identifiable neural correlate stands in need of no further object to explain it.
- C. Fruits demonstrate the object, since a durable moral transformation of the kind James describes could not possibly follow from a false belief.
- D. Experience gives *prima facie* warrant to the subject and testimonial weight to the hearer, with diversity rather than neurology the serious defeater.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: credulity yields defeasible warrant for the one to whom it seems, extended only by testimony, and it never converts a seeming into a public demonstration.
- **B:** Incorrect: correlation identifies mediation, and a defeat additionally requires showing that the mechanism is unreliable or fully explains the seeming without the object.
- **C:** Incorrect: fruits are a criterion of authenticity rather than a proof, and beneficial consequences plainly can follow from beliefs that are false.
- **D:** Correct: this is the graded verdict the clause supports, and diversity outranks neurology because it needs only incompatibility, not a demonstration of unreliability.

Examiner trap 18: Spending the critique on brain regions attacks the weaker defeater; the diversity of incompatible objects is where the argument actually bites.

MCQ 19. The burden carried by a naturalistic explanation

What must a naturalistic explanation establish before it counts as an epistemic defeater?

- A. That the experience was reported by a subject who had an antecedent interest in its turning out to be true rather than illusory.
- B. That the experience can be induced artificially, at least in some subjects, under controlled laboratory conditions.
- C. That the mechanism is unreliable, or that it fully explains the seeming without the proposed object.
- D. That the tradition supplying the interpretation is historically later than the experience it purports to describe and interpret.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: interest is a reason for caution, not a defeater, and applied consistently it would disqualify most testimony including scientific testimony.
- **B:** Incorrect: inducibility shows a sufficient cause, not an unreliable one; ordinary perception can also be induced artificially without becoming non-veridical.
- **C:** Correct: causal explanation and epistemic defeat are different things, so the critic must attack reliability or show that the seeming is fully accounted for without the object.
- **D:** Incorrect: the relative dating of a tradition bears on interpretation rather than on the reliability of the experience-producing mechanism.

Examiner trap 19: "It has a neural correlate, therefore it is nothing" is the mirror image of "it felt overwhelming, therefore it is real"; both skip the burden the argument requires.

MCQ 20. What Alston actually concludes

Alston's conclusion in *Perceiving God* is most accurately stated as which of the following?

- A. Mystical perception has been shown to be reliable, so the beliefs formed within it are justified all things considered and not merely defeasibly.
- B. Religious experience proves God's existence, since the theory of appearing applies to non-sensory presentations as much as to sensory ones.
- C. No belief-forming practice whatever is rational, since not one of them can be validated without falling into epistemic circularity.
- D. Engagement in a socially established religious practice is practically rational, and beliefs formed in it are *prima facie* justified.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Alston expressly denies that reliability has been shown, and his justification is *prima facie* rather than *ultima facie*.
- **B:** Incorrect: the theory of appearing is a claim about the structure of perception, not a proof of an object's existence.
- **C:** Incorrect: it inverts the argument, which uses the circularity of sense perception to defend rather than to condemn practice-based belief.
- **D:** Correct: the conclusion is the practical rationality of engaging in a socially established doxastic practice, with M-beliefs enjoying defeasible justification absent sufficient reason to think the practice unreliable.

Examiner trap 20: Reporting Alston as proving religious experience reliable is the standard overstatement in this clause and is easy for an examiner to detect.

MCQ 21. Alston's own concession, and Hick's price

Which pairing of objection and response is correctly stated?

- A. Alston concedes that incompatible practices cannot all track one reality and answers only that one may rationally "sit tight"; Hick's Real is charged with indeterminacy.
- B. Alston resolves the diversity problem by ranking the competing practices against one another; Hick avoids indeterminacy by describing the Real in detail.
- C. Alston denies that the rival mystical practices are genuinely socially established; Hick denies that the traditions conflict with one another at all.
- D. Alston abandons the parity argument as soon as diversity is raised against him; Hick abandons the Real altogether in favour of a modest exclusivism.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: Alston treats diversity as the most serious objection and offers only rational persistence absent neutral adjudication, while the standing objection to Hick is that an unknowable Real cannot support determinate doctrine.
- **B:** Incorrect: Alston explicitly declines to rank practices, and detailed description of the Real is precisely what Hick's position forbids.
- **C:** Incorrect: he affirms that rival practices are established, which is exactly what generates the objection, and Hick's whole theory is built on the fact of conflict.
- **D:** Incorrect: neither retreats in that way; Alston keeps the parity argument and Hick keeps the Real, each paying a stated price.

Examiner trap 21: Including Alston's own concession is what separates a strong script from a merely correct one; omitting it makes the exposition look second-hand.

MCQ 22. Mystical experience and revelation

Which consideration best shows that mystical experience and revelation are not identical?

- A. Mystical states are ineffable, whereas revelation is by definition fully expressible in a determinate set of communicated propositions.
- B. Revelation always occurs in a public setting before witnesses, whereas mystical experience always occurs in solitude and without observers.
- C. A unitive state may be reported with no disclosure-claim, and truths may be held revealed through a text with no unitive state at all.
- D. Mystical experience concerns the sacred as such, whereas revelation concerns only the moral commands that are issued to a community.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: revelation is not by definition propositional, since the non-propositional model treats it as divine self-disclosure received in an event.
- **B:** Incorrect: the locations are not fixed in that way, and the contrast between public and solitary does not track the distinction at issue.
- **C:** Correct: each case is actual, and each refutes one direction of the identification, which is why the relation is contingent and functional rather than definitional.
- **D:** Incorrect: it narrows revelation arbitrarily to moral content and ignores its standard doctrinal and self-disclosing forms.

Examiner trap 22: The 2023 stem has a second deliverable - the significance of the relation in religious life - and origination, renewal and the risk of unchecked private authority are the three functions to name.

MCQ 23. Prayer, worship, and the cases that decide between them

Which statement captures the essential distinction and its decisive test cases?

- A. Prayer is address presupposing a responsive God; worship is ascription of supreme worth, which Jain and Mīmāṃsā practice retain without petition.
- B. Prayer is characteristically public and worship characteristically private, and the Indian material merely illustrates that difference without deciding it.
- C. Prayer and worship are synonyms in actual practice, and the distinction survives only as a Western liturgical convention.
- D. Worship requires a responsive deity and prayer does not, which is precisely why the non-theistic traditions retain prayer alone and abandon worship.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the essential acts differ - address against ascription of worth - and the Tīrthaṅkara who is free of passion and Mīmāṃsā's unseen potency (*apūrva*) supply full ritual worship where petition can obtain nothing.
- **B:** Incorrect: the locations are reversed, since prayer is often private and worship characteristically corporate, and the Indian cases decide rather than merely illustrate.
- **C:** Incorrect: the distinction generates correct predictions about which traditions retain which practice, so it is not merely verbal or liturgical.
- **D:** Incorrect: it inverts the presuppositions, since responsiveness is what prayer-as-request needs and supreme value is all that worship needs.

Examiner trap 23: The 2020 stem prints two tasks - distinguish, and determine their place - so an answer that stops after the differentia has completed half the question.

MCQ 24. The graded answer on public discourse

Which conclusion answers "how far can religious experience be made a topic of public discourse?" most defensibly?

- A. Fully, since disciplined practices such as meditation and contemplation constitute a genuinely repeatable public experiment open to any observer.
- B. Publicly discussable as description, coherence, tradition-conformity, fruits and practice, but privately probative, since these test authenticity rather than truth.
- C. Not at all, since ineffability and privileged access together make any informative public statement about the experience strictly impossible.
- D. Only politically, since the sole legitimate public question is whether religious reasons may lawfully enter formal state decision-making at all.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the replicability claim must be reported as Vivekananda's and Radhakrishnan's claim and carries its own limit, since the procedure cannot be run by an uncommitted observer.
- **B:** Correct: the six intersubjective criteria are genuinely public and genuinely limited, so the required "how far" is answered by a line drawn between authenticity and evidential transfer.
- **C:** Incorrect: even ineffability is reportable, and James, Otto, Stace and Zaehner built public typologies out of first-person documents.
- **D:** Incorrect: Habermas's translation proviso settles the political sub-question only, leaving the descriptive, doctrinal and practical criteria untouched.

Examiner trap 24: "How far ... Analyse" forbids a yes or a no; the marks are in the line you draw and in your defence of where you drew it.

REMEDIAL DIAGNOSTIC MCQS - 8

MCQ 25. Remedial - "James gives four equally necessary marks of every religious experience"

Which correction is best?

- A. Two marks are defining and two are usual, and all four of them describe mystical states rather than religious experience as such.
- B. All four marks are jointly necessary, but they apply only to conversion experiences rather than to mystical states as James classifies them.
- C. Only one mark is strictly necessary, namely passivity, and the remaining three are optional refinements that some reports happen to add.
- D. The four marks are jointly necessary for religious experience in general, but not for the mystical states that form one variety within it.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: it repairs both halves of the error at once - the grading of the marks and the restriction of their scope to mystical states.
- **B:** Incorrect: it keeps the flat list and then narrows it to the wrong class, since conversion is a separate variety in James's survey.
- **C:** Incorrect: passivity is one of the two merely usual marks and is the least suitable candidate for a single necessary condition.
- **D:** Incorrect: it inverts the scope restriction, extending the marks to religious experience at large while withdrawing them from the states they were formulated for.

Examiner trap 25: Correcting only the scope, or only the grading, leaves half the error standing; state both in one sentence.

MCQ 26. Remedial - "If a mystical experience is ineffable, it is meaningless"

Which reformulation is correct?

- A. Ineffability entails that no true statement whatever can be made about the state, so a disciplined silence is the only honest response available.
- B. Ineffability is a rhetorical exaggeration on the mystic's part, since mystics in fact describe their states at very considerable length.
- C. Ineffability limits the exhaustiveness of report, not the possibility of every statement, so partial and analogical description remains available.
- D. Ineffability applies to the claimed object rather than to the state, so the state itself can in principle be described completely and exactly.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: it treats a limit on adequacy as a prohibition on speech, which would make James's own two lectures of description impossible.
- **B:** Incorrect: dismissing the mark as exaggeration removes one of the two marks James makes definitional rather than explaining it.
- **C:** Correct: the mark restricts adequacy rather than intelligibility, which is why comparative typologies could be built from first-person reports at all.
- **D:** Incorrect: it relocates the mark to the object and then over-claims, since complete description of the state is not what any account here asserts.

Examiner trap 26: Equating ineffability with meaninglessness also destroys the public-discourse answer, because it removes the phenomenological description that the "yes" case is built on.

MCQ 27. Remedial - "Advaita is the perception of Brahman as an object"

Which correction is best?

- A. Advaita treats Brahman as an object of inference rather than of perception, so the correct vocabulary for the realisation is inferential throughout.
- B. Advaita treats the realisation as a non-objective recognition of the self as Brahman, since self-luminous consciousness cannot be an object at all.
- C. Advaita treats Brahman as an object presented within a specially purified perception that becomes available only after very long preparatory discipline.
- D. Advaita treats Brahman as an object throughout the period of practice and as a subject only at the final moment of liberation itself.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: substituting inference for perception keeps the objectifying structure that the doctrine of self-luminosity rejects.
- **B:** Correct: witnessing consciousness is presupposed by subject-object cognition and therefore cannot itself be objectified, so the realisation is recognition rather than presentation.
- **C:** Incorrect: purifying the perception does not remove the objectification; it merely refines it, leaving the same structural error in place.
- **D:** Incorrect: the two-stage account is not Advaita's, and it would make the decisive structural claim depend on a change of standpoint at the last moment.

Examiner trap 27: Answers that say "experience of Brahman" invite the dualising objection even when the surrounding paragraph is correct; change the phrase, not just the argument.

MCQ 28. Remedial - "Otto's holy and Durkheim's sacred are the same idea"

Which correction is best?

- A. They are one and the same idea expressed in two different disciplinary vocabularies, so nothing philosophical whatever turns on the difference between them.
- B. They differ only in their intended scope, since Otto's account covers the theistic religions and Durkheim's covers the tribal and totemic ones.
- C. Otto analyses a phenomenological quality disclosed in awe, while Durkheim analyses a social classification defined by separation and by prohibition.
- D. Otto analyses a social classification and Durkheim a phenomenological quality, so the attribution usually made in textbooks is exactly reversed.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the difference determines which objection each account faces, so treating it as terminological removes the evaluative content of the module.
- **B:** Incorrect: the contrast is one of method rather than of coverage, and Durkheim's definition is designed to be perfectly general.
- **C:** Correct: one describes how an object appears to a subject in numinous awe, the other describes how a community sets something apart, and each attracts a different criticism.
- **D:** Incorrect: it simply transposes the two authors, which is the same error in a different direction.

Examiner trap 28: This distinction is worth stating explicitly even in answers that are not about 2018, because it also disciplines the use of "sacred" as the generic object-term.

MCQ 29. Remedial - "Alston proved that religious experience is reliable"

Which correction is best?

- A. Alston proved reliability for one practice only, namely the Christian mystical one, and left every other established religious practice unexamined.
- B. Alston proved that religious experience is in fact unreliable, and therefore defends religious belief entirely on grounds that are not experiential.
- C. Alston abandoned the reliability question altogether and defended religious belief instead as properly basic in Plantinga's Reformed-epistemology sense.
- D. Alston argues only for the practical rationality of engaging in an established practice, since no practice at all can ever be validated non-circularly.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: no reliability proof is offered for any practice, and rival practices are precisely what he concedes he cannot adjudicate.
- **B:** Incorrect: it inverts his conclusion, since he defends the rationality of engagement rather than attacking the practice.
- **C:** Incorrect: proper basicity is Plantinga's apparatus in the Reformed-epistemology debate; Alston's route is the parity of doxastic practices.
- **D:** Correct: the parity argument yields practical rationality and *prima facie* justification for M-beliefs, not a demonstration of reliability.

Examiner trap 29: Overstating Alston also weakens the answer, because the overstated version is easy to refute while the accurate version shifts the burden onto the sceptic.

MCQ 30. Remedial - "The experience has a neural correlate, so it is nothing"

Which correction is best?

- A. Neural correlates are wholly absent in the genuine mystical states, and that absence is what distinguishes them from episodes of ordinary perception.
- B. Neural correlation shows mediation; a defeat further requires showing unreliability, or a full explanation of the seeming without the object.
- C. Neural correlation is wholly irrelevant to philosophy of religion and should therefore be excluded from any philosophical answer entirely.
- D. Neural correlation proves veridicality, since the presence of a physical basis shows that the experience in question was not merely imagined.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the empirical claim is unsupported, and the position would make mystical states uniquely disembodied for no stated reason.
- **B:** Correct: causal explanation and epistemic defeat are different things, so the critic must attack reliability or show that the seeming is fully accounted for without the proposed object.
- **C:** Incorrect: the material is legitimate as a form of the naturalistic critique; what is illegitimate is treating correlation as conclusion.
- **D:** Incorrect: it commits the mirror error, converting a mechanism into a warrant instead of into a defeat.

Examiner trap 30: The clause's own guidance restricts dated news anchors and warns against filling answers with brain-region catalogues; one accurate sentence on mediation is worth more than a paragraph of neuroscience.

MCQ 31. Remedial - "Indian mysticism is one thing"

Which correction is best?

- A. Indian traditions differ only over the deity that is named, since every one of them culminates in a loving union with some personal Lord.
- B. Indian traditions differ only over the method employed, since every one of them culminates in the same non-dual realisation of one reality.
- C. Indian traditions all agree with Zaehner's monistic type, so the whole comparison can safely be run on a single row of the bench.
- D. Indian traditions report at least four different structures - identity, isolation, relation and insight - with four different termini.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: union with a personal Lord is the devotional structure alone and is explicitly denied by Advaita's identity-claim and by Buddhist analysis.
- **B:** Incorrect: it assimilates Yoga, devotion and Buddhism to Advaita, which is the very assimilation charge pressed against Radhakrishnan.
- **C:** Incorrect: Zaehner's monistic type does not accommodate devotional relation or Buddhist insight, so a single row cannot carry the comparison.
- **D:** Correct: Advaita reports identity, Sāṃkhya-Yoga isolation, devotional traditions a graced relation and Buddhism insight terminating in cessation, and each carries its own control.

Examiner trap 31: A comparison paragraph that says "Indian mysticism" without naming a structure reads as second-hand even when its individual facts are correct.

MCQ 32. Remedial - answering only one of two printed deliverables

A stem reads: "Distinguish between prayer and worship and determine their place in religion." A script gives an excellent six-axis distinction and stops. What is the correct diagnosis?

- A. The script has completed one of two separately marked tasks, so its ceiling is set by the missing placement analysis.
- B. The script is complete as it stands, since determining their place in religion follows automatically once the essential distinction has been drawn.
- C. The script has failed outright, because a distinction offered without supporting examples cannot be credited by an examiner at all.
- D. The script should have omitted the distinction entirely, since the instruction to determine their place already subsumes the earlier task.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: six of the eight printed stems in this clause carry two deliverables, and a complete treatment of the first alone caps the script below its content value.
- **B:** Incorrect: placement requires a further argument about the relational and evaluative functions of each practice, which no distinction supplies by itself.
- **C:** Incorrect: an excellent distinction is creditable work; the defect is incompleteness, not worthlessness.
- **D:** Incorrect: the stem prints both tasks, and dropping the first would forfeit the marks allocated to it.

Examiner trap 32: Decode the directive before writing: "distinguish ... and determine", "examine ... and expound", "nature and variety", "nature and object" are all double-barrelled, and the second barrel is where scripts most often fail.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Verified previous-year questions - 8 complete solutions

Word bands used throughout. 10 marks ≈ 150 words · 15 marks ≈ 250 words · 20 marks ≈ 350 words. Every question below is reproduced in its **exact printed wording** from the audited Philosophy of Religion previous-year ledger, 2018-2025, in which this clause owns exactly one part in every paper. **The model answers are independent learner practice and are never official UPSC keys.**

Timing skeleton. 10 marks - 1 minute to decode, 1 to outline, 6 to write, 1 to check. 15 marks - 1 / 2 / 10 / 2. 20 marks - 2 / 3 / 13 / 2. **Standing penalties in this clause:** an ungraded four-mark list; an unanswered second deliverable; a verdict that summarises instead of deciding; and any invented year for Schleiermacher, Swinburne, Hick, Forman or Teresa.

PYQ 1 - 2018, Q7(a), 20 marks

Exact verified question: The terms 'Sacred' and 'Holy' have come to serve as generic names for the object of religion. Do you agree that one can have God as the object of religion? Discuss.

Demand decoding: Explain why "sacred" and "holy" can cover religion generally; distinguish their major meanings; then give a graded answer on whether God may be religion's object without making God its universally necessary object.

Model solution: The "object of religion" is that ultimate reality, power, state or value toward which religious consciousness and practice are directed. My thesis is graded: God can certainly be the object of religion in theistic traditions, but cannot define the object of religion generically. "Sacred" is the broader comparative category; God is the theistic paradigm within it.

The terms "holy" and "sacred" are not exact synonyms. In *The Idea of the Holy*, Rudolf Otto treats the Holy, prior to its moral schematisation, as the **numinous**—the *mysterium tremendum et fascinans*. Its object is experienced as mysterious and "wholly other," producing creature-feeling, dread and fascination. Otto's account is phenomenological: it describes how the object appears. Emile Durkheim, by contrast, defines the sacred socially through its separation from the profane and the prohibitions and communal practices surrounding it. Mircea Eliade adds the idea of **hierophany**: the sacred manifests and structures religious space, time and orientation. Thus Otto's holy is a distinctive quality disclosed in experience, whereas Durkheim's sacred is a social classification. Collapsing them obscures the difference between phenomenology and function.

These generic terms are useful because religion is wider than theism. Buddhism relates life to Dharma, nirvāṇa and awakening without a creator-God. Jainism venerates the liberated Tīrthaṅkara and *siddha*, not a world-creating deity. Mīmāṃsā treats the Veda as *apauruṣeya* and ritual efficacy through *apūrva*, without requiring a divine author or grantor. Indian categories such as *pavitra*, *maṅgala*, *tīrtha* and *kṣetra* also show that purity, auspiciousness, sacred space and soteriological power—not only Otto's awe—organise religious life.

Nevertheless, God can be the object of religion. In classical theism, Judaism, Islam, Christianity, Viśiṣṭādvaita and many bhakti traditions, prayer, worship and revelation are intentionally directed toward a personal divine reality. God is not merely one sacred item among others but the source and measure of holiness: persons, texts and places are holy through relation to God. "Object" here must not imply an ordinary finite object passively inspected. It means the intentional pole of faith, worship and encounter—an inexhaustible subject who addresses the worshipper.

Two objections qualify this account. First, "sacred" may become so broad that flags, nations or celebrities count as religious objects. The reply is to add a **soteriological condition**: the religiously sacred is related to the diagnosis and overcoming of the fundamental human predicament. Second, a theist may object that calling God a "species" of the sacred subordinates God to a higher genus. The reply is conceptual, not ontological: comparative philosophy needs a category covering diverse religions; it does not deny the theist's claim that God is ontologically ultimate.

Finally, identifying a claimed object must be separated from establishing its reality. Otto may accurately describe numinous intentionality without proving a numinous being, just as Durkheim may explain sacred classification without exhausting its possible transcendent reference. The phenomenology of an object, the specification of that object and the warrant for believing it exists are distinct questions.

An Indian-Western comparison further qualifies the word "object." In theistic mysticism and prayer, God is encountered through an I-Thou relation. Radhakrishnan and Advaita, however, interpret the highest realisation non-dually: Brahman is not confronted as an Other but realised as the depth of self. Buddhism may regard even substantial "object" language as misleading. Hence comparative philosophy must allow object to mean the ultimate intentional or soteriological pole, not invariably a separately existing personal being.

Therefore, one can have God as the object of religion, decisively so within theism. But God cannot serve as religion's universal defining object without excluding non-theistic religions by stipulation. The best verdict is: **the sacred is the comparative genus; God is theism's paradigm instance and, for the believer, the source of all holiness.**

Why this earns marks: Directly answers the "do you agree" clause; distinguishes Otto, Durkheim and Eliade; supplies Indian non-theistic counter-cases; separates object from warrant; handles two objections; ends with a graded verdict.

PYQ 2 - 2019, Q7(c), 15 marks

Exact verified question: How far can religious experience be made a topic of public discourse? Analyse.

Demand decoding: Give a degree, not a yes/no. Separate public description and assessment from public proof, identify limits created by privacy and ineffability, and state precisely what remains publicly discussable.

Model solution: Religious experience can enter public discourse extensively as **reported data, interpreted meaning and disciplined practice**, but only limitedly as publicly compelling evidence for its transcendent object. The crucial distinction is between discussing an experience, testing the authenticity of its report and proving what the experience claims to disclose.

The case against public discourse begins with first-person privacy. William James calls mystical states ineffable and grants them authority primarily for the experiencer, not for outsiders. Their felt certainty is not transferable. Unlike ordinary perception, there may be no neutral procedure by which observers reproduce the episode and correct misidentification. Wittgenstein's private-language considerations deepen the worry: a wholly private criterion cannot sustain a stable distinction between seeming right and being right. In political settings, Rawlsian public reason also bars private revelation from functioning as a coercive reason binding citizens who do not share it.

Yet privacy does not entail silence. First, **phenomenological descriptions** are public: James, Otto, Stace and Zaehner constructed comparative classifications from first-person testimony. Even saying that an experience is ineffable conveys its limits and effects; ineffability means resistance to exhaustive expression, not unintelligibility. Second, reports can be tested for internal coherence, consistency with other beliefs and absence of obvious pathology or manipulation. Third, traditions maintain public rules of discernment-spiritual direction, doctrinal checks and the guru's examination of a disciple. Fourth, James's test by "fruits" concerns observable moral integration and conduct, though good effects establish authenticity more readily than metaphysical truth.

The Indian contribution strengthens the intersubjective case. *Yoga, dhyāna* and *śravaṇa-manana-nididhyāsana* are presented as disciplined procedures with stated preconditions and expected transformations. This is not laboratory replication, because training and commitment shape access; nevertheless, it resembles expert perception, which also requires acquired capacities. William Alston's account of socially established doxastic practices similarly makes religious experience a legitimate subject of public argument about inputs, outputs and override procedures, while not proving the practice reliable from a neutral standpoint.

The strongest objection remains that these criteria test sincerity, coherence and authenticity, not the existence of God or Brahman. That objection should be conceded. Habermas offers an appropriate political analogue: religious claims may enter the informal public sphere in their own language, but must be translated into generally accessible reasons before formal state decisions.

Thus religious experience is publicly discussable in description, comparison, interpretation, moral consequences and disciplined modes of cultivation. Its first-person evidential force, however, cannot be transferred intact. The analytically defensible verdict is: **publicly assessable and privately probative, but not publicly demonstrative.**

Why this earns marks: Obeyes "how far"; distinguishes discourse, authenticity and truth; uses James, Wittgenstein, Alston and Indian disciplines; concedes the decisive limitation; gives a precise graded conclusion.

PYQ 3 - 2020, Q7(b), 15 marks

Exact verified question: Distinguish between prayer and worship and determine their place in religion.

Demand decoding: Complete both tasks: establish the essential differentia between prayer and worship, including overlap and non-theistic cases, and then explain the distinct function of each in religious life.

Model solution: Prayer and worship overlap, especially in adoration, but they are not synonyms. **Prayer is address or communication directed toward the divine; worship is the acknowledgement and enactment of supreme worth.** Prayer normally presupposes an addressee capable of hearing; worship requires only a reality regarded as ultimately valuable.

Prayer may be verbal or silent, spontaneous or prescribed, private or congregational. Its classical forms are summarised by ACTS: adoration, confession, thanksgiving and supplication; intercession and contemplative prayer may be added. Worship is characteristically embodied, ritual and communal-prostration, liturgy, offering, praise and sacred observance. Adoration is the intersection: as address it is prayer; as attribution of unsurpassable worth it is worship. Petition, however, is prayer without necessarily being the core of worship.

Wordless contemplation is a limit case: communicative directedness can remain even when articulated requests disappear, so silence alone does not convert prayer into worship.

This distinction exposes different philosophical problems. Petitionary prayer appears redundant if God is omniscient, perfectly good and immutable: God already knows the need, wills the best and cannot be altered. Aquinas replies that prayer does not change the divine will; God may ordain that certain goods be obtained **through** prayer, making it a secondary cause. Eleonore Stump further argues that asking has relational value: it preserves a friendship-like structure between giver and recipient. The reply explains prayer's place even if it does not prove that events causally depend on petitions.

Worship faces James Rachels' autonomy objection: unconditional obedience seems incompatible with responsible moral agency. But worship need not mean surrendering moral judgement. It can be recognition of perfect worth, gratitude and self-transformation; obedience to a perfectly good being would not license evil.

Indian traditions show why worship is broader than prayer. Jain *caitya-vandana* honours a *vītarāga* Tīrthaṅkara who neither intervenes nor answers petitions. Mīmāṃsā locates ritual efficacy in *apūrva*, not a granting deity. Buddhist *pūjā* can be commemorative and dispositional. Advaita treats *upāsana* of saṁyama Brahman as spiritually effective at the *vyāvahārika* level, though ultimately transcended in non-dual knowledge. Hence worship survives where petitionary address is absent.

Prayer is religion's **relational organ**: it gives practical form to dependence, trust, confession and hope. Worship is its **evaluative and communal organ**: it marks the sacred as ultimate, forms a community and disciplines desire through embodied practice. A religion may survive without petition; it cannot survive without worship in the broad sense of orienting life toward what is held supremely valuable. Therefore worship is more nearly universal, while prayer expresses the specifically dialogical dimension of religion.

Why this earns marks: Gives a sharp essential distinction, identifies overlap, addresses petition and autonomy, uses Aquinas, Stump and Rachels, adds decisive Indian non-theistic cases, and determines each practice's religious function.

PYQ 4 - 2021, Q7(c), 15 marks

Exact verified question: Explain the concept of religious experience in the light of Vedāntic tradition.

Demand decoding: Use Vedānta's own categories and acknowledge internal plurality. Explain immediate realisation, its preparation, nature and object, then distinguish Advaitic identity from qualified-non-dual and dualistic encounter.

Model solution: In Vedānta, religious experience is not merely an intense feeling but the culmination of a disciplined search for liberating knowledge of the relation among self, world and Brahman. Its common aspiration is **direct realisation-anubhava** or *aparokṣānubhūti*-yet Vedāntic schools differ on whether this realisation is identity with Brahman or communion with a distinct Lord.

The Upaniṣadic background gives priority to transformative knowledge. Scripture (*śruti*) discloses what sense perception cannot, reason removes contradiction, and spiritual discipline makes the aspirant fit for realisation. Thus experience is not an isolated psychological episode. It arises through ethical preparation, hearing (*śravaṇa*), reflection (*manana*), meditation (*nididhyāsa*), devotion or divine grace, according to the school concerned.

For Śaṅkara's Advaita, the highest experience is the non-objective recognition that ātman is Brahman, articulated by *aham brahmāsmi*. Subject-object duality belongs to ignorance; Brahman cannot be confronted as an external object because it is self-luminous consciousness presupposed by every act of knowing. The realisation is non-dual, self-certifying and liberating, and stable *jñāna* is more important than a passing ecstasy. It is beyond exhaustive objectifying language, but not unintelligible. Nor should it be called *anirvacanīya*: technically, that term characterises māyā or world-appearance, not Brahman-realisation.

Rāmānuja's Viśiṣṭādvaita rejects the erasure of difference. Brahman is personal, with selves and world as real modes dependent upon God. Religious fulfilment therefore takes the form of loving knowledge, devotion and communion, not the disappearance of the worshipper. Madhva's Dvaita makes the distinction stronger: God and soul remain eternally different, and saving experience is a grace-enabled relation to Viṣṇu. Vedānta consequently includes both **identity-recognition** and **intentional encounter**.

The epistemic status also varies accordingly. Advaita calls realisation self-certifying because self-luminous consciousness is not established through a second cognition. Devotional schools place greater weight on scripture, grace and the transformed relation of dependence. In every case, however, the experience is soteriological: it is assessed by whether it removes ignorance, egoism and bondage, not simply by its emotional intensity. This distinguishes Vedāntic *anubhava* from an unregulated private impression.

An objection follows: if these accounts have incompatible structures, "Vedāntic experience" may be only doctrinal interpretation imposed upon ambiguous states. The reply is not to manufacture a flat common core. Rather, mediation need not equal fabrication: each school offers a disciplined practice, conceptual grammar and tests of transformation through which experience is identified. Still, these internal criteria do not by themselves prove the metaphysical object to outsiders.

Therefore Vedāntic religious experience is best understood as tradition-guided, transformative and soteriological directness to the Real. Its distinctive philosophical range runs from Advaita's non-dual self-recognition to the devotional schools' enduring relation with a personal Brahman.

Why this earns marks: Uses internal Vedāntic vocabulary; covers preparation and liberation; distinguishes Śaṅkara, Rāmānuja and Madhva; preserves identity-versus-relation; handles the mediation objection without flattening differences.

PYQ 5 - 2022, Q7(c), 15 marks

Exact verified question: Discuss the nature and variety of religious experiences as presented by William James.

Demand decoding: Present James's empirical-pragmatic method, correctly grade the marks of mystical states, and cover the wider varieties of personal religion rather than reducing the answer to a flat four-item list.

Model solution: In *The Varieties of Religious Experience*, William James studies religion empirically through first-person documents and pragmatically through its effects on life. Religious experience is primarily personal before it becomes institutional, and its value cannot be dismissed merely by tracing a neurological or pathological origin. James calls such dismissal "medical materialism": causal origin alone does not decide truth or worth.

James's celebrated four marks apply specifically to **mystical states**, not to all religious experience, and they are not equal. **Ineffability** and **noetic quality** are the two defining marks. The experience cannot be adequately conveyed to one who has not undergone it, yet it presents itself as insight into depths unavailable to discursive intellect. Ineffability is therefore not unintelligibility, and noetic force is felt authority rather than independently demonstrated knowledge.

Transiency and **passivity** are usual but less sharply marked accompaniments. Mystical states are commonly brief; once they begin, the subject feels grasped by a superior power, though voluntary practices may prepare their onset.

James's "variety" is broader than mysticism. He contrasts healthy-minded religion, which affirms goodness and harmony, with the religion of the "sick soul," acutely conscious of evil, guilt and dividedness. The divided self seeks unification, often through conversion. Saintliness names the durable moral and affective fruits of religious transformation. Mysticism represents the direct experiential pole in which the self feels connected with a wider "MORE," sometimes mediated through the subconscious. James accordingly judges religious life by enduring fruits rather than unusual intensity alone.

These forms are not a rigid hierarchy. James's case-based method asks how temperaments confront evil, attain unification and produce a workable religious life. It preserves plurality within personal religion instead of deriving every case from one creed.

His great strength is methodological openness: he takes testimony seriously without allowing private conviction to coerce outsiders. Mystical experience may rationally authorise the experiencer, but it establishes no unconditional authority over others. This is also the limit of his epistemology. Good fruits may authenticate transformation but cannot prove that the "MORE" exists; culturally conflicting experiences intensify the problem.

An Indian comparison clarifies James's own grading. Advaitic *jñāna* can be stable and established rather than transient, and the culmination of disciplined inquiry rather than sheer passivity. It can still qualify as mystical because James makes ineffability and noetic quality defining, while transiency and passivity are only usual.

Thus James offers a rich phenomenology and psychology of personal religion-healthy-mindedness, sick soul, conversion, saintliness and mysticism-while keeping its metaphysical object open. His account is strongest as empirical classification and pragmatic assessment, not as a proof of veridicality.

Why this earns marks: Correctly grades James's marks; covers method, "medical materialism," "MORE," conversion and saintliness; distinguishes personal authority from public proof; uses Indian comparison analytically.

PYQ 6 - 2023, Q8(c), 15 marks

Exact verified question: Examine the relation between mystical experience and revelation and expound their significance in the religious life.

Demand decoding: Define both terms, analyse several possible relations without identifying them, and then separately explain what each contributes to religious life, including criteria that limit private revelation.

Model solution: Mystical experience is an immediate or apparently immediate awareness of, union with or identity in ultimate reality. Revelation is disclosure of religious truth or divine reality. They may converge, but they are not identical: mystical experience concerns a mode of consciousness, while revelation concerns disclosure and its claimed authority.

Their relation can take three forms. First, mystical experience may be a **vehicle of non-propositional revelation**: God or the Real is disclosed through presence rather than sentences. Otto's numinous encounter and theistic mysticism exemplify disclosure as experienced relation. Second, propositions may arise as interpretations of the experience; the experience is primary, while doctrines articulate what was encountered. William James's noetic quality explains why mystics regard their states as revelatory, but James restricts their authority to the subject. Third, prior revelation can discipline experience. A scriptural and ritual tradition supplies categories, practices and criteria through which an episode is cultivated and identified.

The relation differs in Indian traditions. In Advaita, *śruti* does not reveal Brahman as an external object. It removes ignorance and prepares *aparokṣānubhūti*, the recognition that ātman is Brahman. Here revelation and mystical realisation are complementary: textual testimony points, reason clarifies, and non-dual awareness fulfils the teaching. Theistic Vedānta, by contrast, can interpret mystical experience as grace-enabled communion with a personal God, preserving knower-known relation.

Their significance in religious life is substantial. Revelation supplies orientation, a shared narrative and normative content; mystical experience vivifies these rather than leaving them as second-hand belief. It can deepen prayer and worship, produce conversion, unify the divided self and renew institutions through prophetic or saintly witness. Its moral fruits also provide public evidence of transformation, even when its object remains disputed.

Conversely, revelation without lived appropriation can harden into external authority, while mysticism without revelatory or rational regulation can become incommunicable or self-authorising. Their conjunction gives religious life both experiential depth and accountable form.

The strongest objection is epistemic: private experiences generate conflicting revelations and can legitimate fanaticism. Steven Katz's constructivism adds that traditions may shape the experience itself, not merely its later description. The reply must be discriminating, not credulous. Mediation does not automatically mean fabrication, since ordinary perception is concept-laden too; nevertheless, claims require tests of coherence, moral fruits, tradition-sensitive discernment and compatibility with responsible reason. Such tests establish authenticity more readily than metaphysical truth.

Therefore mystical experience may mediate and personally confirm revelation, while revelation may interpret and regulate mystical life. Their significance lies in joining lived transformation to inherited meaning. But no private mystical claim should acquire unconditional public or moral authority merely because it feels self-certifying.

Why this earns marks: Defines both poles; gives three relations; integrates James, Otto, Katz and Advaita; explains religious significance separately; confronts conflict and fanaticism; ends with a qualified assessment.

PYQ 7 - 2024, Q8(c), 15 marks

Exact verified question: Discuss the main features of religious experience according to Advaita Vedānta.

Demand decoding: Enumerate Advaita's distinctive features in tradition-specific terms, explain how its "object" differs from an intentional object, and assess the content and criterion objection.

Model solution: For Advaita Vedānta, the highest religious experience is not a subject's encounter with an external God but the immediate recognition of non-dual reality: ātman is Brahman. Its central term is *aparokṣānubhūti*, direct realisation, and its soteriological result is the destruction of ignorance and liberation.

First, the experience is **non-dual**. Ordinary cognition divides knower, knowing and known; Advaita regards this division as conditioned by *avidyā*. In liberating knowledge the supposed separation is sublated. *Aham brahmāsmi* therefore expresses identity, not proximity or emotional union between two already constituted beings.

Second, it is **self-luminous and self-certifying**. Consciousness is not known through another act, since every act of knowing presupposes it. Brahman, as the reality of consciousness, cannot be converted into an object without reproducing the duality to be overcome. The "object" of experience is thus realised as one's own Self; strictly, the object-pole disappears.

Third, the realisation is beyond exhaustive objectifying speech. Upaniṣadic negation such as *neti neti* removes limiting predicates, while mahāvākyas disclose identity. This is not meaninglessness. Nor is the realisation technically *anirvacanīya*: in Advaita that term characterises māyā or world-appearance as neither simply real nor unreal. Brahman is real; its non-objectifiability is better expressed through the limits of speech.

Fourth, the experience is transformative and blissful (*ānanda*), terminating bondage rooted in misidentification. Fifth, it is not merely a brief altered state. *Śravaṇa*, *manana* and *nididhyāsana* culminate in stable *jñāna*. James's transiency and passivity are therefore, at most, usual marks of many mystical episodes, not requirements Advaita must satisfy.

Sixth, Advaita distinguishes the empirical and ultimate standpoints. Devotion and *upāsana* directed toward saṁgha Brahman remain valid and purificatory at the *vyāvahārika* level; non-dual knowledge discloses nirguṇa Brahman at the *pāramārthika* level. They are not simply discarded as meaningless. This graded structure explains how intentional religious practice can prepare for a realisation in which intentional duality is finally overcome.

The strongest objection is that a contentless, non-dual state cannot justify the determinate judgement "I am Brahman"; perhaps doctrine constructs the interpretation. Advaita replies that *śruti* functions as a *pramāṇa* that removes ignorance rather than producing a new object. Like the tenth-man instruction, it discloses an already present fact; disciplined reflection blocks arbitrary interpretation. Still, this establishes tradition-internal intelligibility more readily than public proof.

Hence Advaitic religious experience is immediate, non-dual, self-luminous, non-objective, liberating and stabilised as knowledge. Its philosophical distinctiveness lies in **identity-recognition**, unlike Otto's encounter with the wholly other or theistic mysticism's relation to a personal God.

Why this earns marks: Lists and explains the main features; avoids the *anirvacanīya* error; uses mahāvākya and method; contrasts identity with encounter; presents the strongest objection and a bounded reply.

PYQ 8 - 2025, Q8(a), 20 marks

Exact verified question: Evaluate the nature and object of Religious Experience as explained by Radhakrishnan in 'The Hindu View of Life'.

Demand decoding: Remain faithful to the named work; separately identify the nature and object of experience; explain the priority of experience over dogma and ritual; then evaluate universality, mediation and veridicality with a graded verdict.

Model solution: In *The Hindu View of Life*, S. Radhakrishnan presents religion fundamentally as realised spiritual life rather than assent to a closed creed. My thesis is that his account powerfully explains the immediacy, integrality and transformative force of religious experience, but its movement from experiential certainty to a universal spiritual object remains philosophically contestable.

The **nature** of religious experience is direct *anubhava*: an immediate, intuitive apprehension of reality, not a conclusion mechanically inferred from sense-data or discursive reasoning. Radhakrishnan's "intuition" is not a hunch or anti-intellectual feeling. It is an **integral awareness** in which cognition, feeling and will are unified. Discursive reason analyses and divides; spiritual intuition apprehends wholes and transforms the person. It is therefore noetic as well as affective, and its authenticity appears in a reorientation of conduct and character.

The experience is also self-certifying for the subject. Its immediacy resembles the Advaitic claim that consciousness is self-revealing. Yet Radhakrishnan does not treat religious life as a licence for arbitrary private impressions. Preparation, ethical purification, contemplation and the inherited wisdom of the tradition discipline intuition. Experience is primary, but reason remains necessary to interpret it, compare claims and prevent fanaticism.

Its **object** is the spiritual Real or Spirit that is also the depth of the self. Religious experience overcomes the ordinary separation of subject and object; the ultimate is not encountered as one finite item among others. In this Advaitically inflected account, one does not merely perceive God from outside but participates in or realises a deeper unity of self and reality. Nevertheless, Radhakrishnan allows personal symbols and devotional forms a genuine place in finite religious life. The impersonal and personal are not simply competing deities; personal conceptions can mediate an ultimate reality exceeding complete conceptual determination.

This priority of experience explains his view of Hinduism as non-dogmatic and dynamically receptive. Creeds, rituals, myths and institutions are secondary formulations of realised spiritual depth. Their plurality need not prove that the Real is plural; it may show that one depth is interpreted through different histories and temperaments. His view thus supports inter-religious hospitality and gives Indian *anubhava* parity with Western appeals to revelation or mystical encounter.

Several comparisons sharpen the account. Like James, Radhakrishnan treats personal experience and transformative fruits as more fundamental than institution, but he makes a stronger metaphysical claim about spiritual reality. Unlike Otto's intentional encounter with the numinous "wholly other," his highest experience tends toward non-dual integration. Like Advaita, he distinguishes non-objective realisation from ordinary perception, though his comparative philosophy emphasises universality across traditions.

Three objections arise. First, self-certifying certainty for the subject is not public proof of the object. Swinburne's principle of credulity may grant prima facie warrant absent defeaters, and Alston may defend rational participation in an established doxastic practice, but neither establishes Radhakrishnan's Spirit conclusively. Second, religious diversity may resist reduction to one experiential core: theistic communion, Buddhist emptiness and Advaitic identity differ logically, not merely verbally. Radhakrishnan risks assimilating them to Advaita. A modest reply is to claim family resemblance and analogous transformation rather than identical content. Third, constructivists argue that concepts and practices shape experience itself. The proper answer is that **mediation is not necessarily fabrication**; all perception is interpreted. Yet this reply also requires abandoning the claim of a wholly tradition-free intuition.

Radhakrishnan is therefore strongest as a phenomenology and philosophy of lived religion: he explains why spiritual realisation precedes, animates and criticises dogma. He is less decisive as an epistemologist, because intensity, self-certification and good fruits do not by themselves prove a common spiritual object. The graded verdict is that his account gives religious experience prima facie personal authority and profound comparative value, while the universality and veridicality of its object remain defensible hypotheses rather than demonstrated conclusions.

Why this earns marks: Anchors the answer in *The Hindu View of Life*; separates nature from object; explains integral intuition and secondary dogma; compares James, Otto and Advaita; tests universality, constructivism and warrant;

delivers an evaluative verdict.

Original solved Mains practice - 6 models

The following are original, independently prepared practice questions and model answers, not UPSC PYQs or official solutions.

Original 1 · 10 marks

Question: Does the ineffability of religious experience prevent it from yielding knowledge? Examine.

Model solution: Ineffability limits the communication and doctrinal use of religious experience, but it does not automatically prevent every kind of knowledge. The issue turns on distinguishing **knowledge by acquaintance**, partial propositional articulation and publicly demonstrable knowledge.

William James identifies ineffability and noetic quality as the defining marks of mystical states. The mystic cannot adequately transfer the quality of the state to a non-participant, yet experiences it as insight into a deeper reality. This is not self-contradictory. Taste and pain also exceed complete description while supporting correct first-person judgements. Mystics can additionally make limited claims-unity, peace, dependence or non-duality-without claiming exhaustive capture.

Religious language may therefore function negatively, analogically or symbolically: it can exclude false literal pictures and direct attention without reproducing the experience. Such disciplined partial speech is weaker than a complete definition but stronger than silence.

However, noetic feeling is not sufficient warrant. If an experience is wholly ineffable, determinate inferences such as "a personal creator exists" may outrun its content. Conflicting reports of God, Brahman and emptiness strengthen this objection. Good moral fruits establish transformation more readily than the metaphysical truth of the interpretation.

A qualified reply distinguishes the experience from its interpretation. Negative and analogical language may communicate boundaries; traditions can test coherence, preparation and fruits. Advaita similarly treats Brahman as non-objectifiable but uses *śruti* and reason to remove error. Still, these resources give tradition-internal articulation, not coercive public proof.

Therefore ineffability does not reduce religious experience to unintelligibility. It may yield immediate or acquaintance-like knowledge and defeasible personal warrant, but it restricts exhaustive description and weakens the move to detailed, universally binding doctrine.

Why this earns marks: Direct thesis; James correctly graded; acquaintance/proposition/public-proof distinction; diversity objection; Advaita comparison; qualified verdict.

Original 2 · 10 marks

Question: Compare Otto's numinous encounter with Advaita's non-dual awareness as two accounts of religious experience.

Model solution: Otto and Advaita both resist reducing religion to discursive belief, but their experiences have fundamentally different logical structures: Otto describes an **intentional encounter with an Other**, whereas Advaita describes **identity-recognition in which otherness is sublated**.

In *The Idea of the Holy*, Otto calls the object the numinous, experienced as *mysterium tremendum et fascinans*. The subject feels creaturely, overwhelmed and yet attracted before the "wholly other." "Non-rational" means irreducible to ordinary moral and conceptual predicates, not irrational. The subject and numinous object remain distinct.

Advaita's *aparokṣānubhūti* is direct recognition that ātman is Brahman. Since self-luminous consciousness presupposes every objectifying cognition, Brahman cannot be one external item perceived by a subject. *Aham brahmāsmi* expresses non-dual identity. The realisation is liberating and stabilised as *jñāna*, not necessarily the transient passivity often found in mystical episodes.

Both accounts stress immediacy, non-exhaustive language and transformation. Yet assimilating them into a single "mystical feeling" erases the difference between relation and identity. The strongest objection to Otto is that awe may be psychologically explained without a numinous object; the strongest objection to Advaita is that a contentless state cannot justify the specific judgement of Brahman-identity. Otto can reply that causal explanation does not exhaust intentional structure; Advaita replies that *śruti* removes ignorance rather than constructing an object.

Their soteriological orientations also differ. Otto's analysis begins from a creature's response to holiness and awaits ethical-theological schematisation; Advaita places the experience within a path whose cognitive culmination removes *avidyā*. The former centres reverent encounter, the latter liberating knowledge.

Thus the accounts are comparable as non-discursive phenomenologies, but not interchangeable. Otto preserves encounter; Advaita culminates in non-dual recognition.

Why this earns marks: Clear comparator; precise doctrines; non-rational clarified; identity-versus-relation made decisive; matched objections and replies; concise verdict.

Original 3 · 15 marks

Question: "The moral fruits of a religious experience authenticate the subject but do not verify the transcendent object." Critically discuss.

Model solution: The proposition is substantially correct: moral fruits are powerful evidence that an experience has reorganised a life and may count against pathology or self-deception, but they do not by themselves verify God, Brahman or another transcendent object.

William James evaluates religion pragmatically "by its fruits," examining conversion, saintliness, integration of the divided self and durable conduct rather than extraordinary intensity. This criterion has three strengths. First, effects are publicly observable even when the original state is private. Second, enduring compassion, courage and freedom from ego provide evidence that the report is not a fleeting mood. Third, fruits allow comparison across traditions without requiring prior agreement about theology. Indian traditions similarly test realisation through freedom from attachment, ethical discipline and transformed conduct; the guru does not accept every ecstasy as liberating knowledge.

Nevertheless, beneficial consequences do not entail metaphysical truth. A false belief can inspire sacrifice, while a veridical perception can produce no moral improvement. Different religions generate admirable lives while making incompatible claims about a personal God, non-dual Brahman or emptiness. To infer a transcendent object solely from fruits commits a pragmatic substitution: usefulness replaces truth. Further, social approval of "good fruits" may reflect the evaluator's own moral norms.

A defender can offer a cumulative rather than deductive argument. Fruits may raise credibility when joined with coherent phenomenology, reliable character, disciplined preparation, absence of known defeaters and convergence of testimony. Swinburne's principle of credulity permits an initial presumption in favour of apparent experience; transformation may strengthen that presumption by making deception less likely. Alston's doxastic-practice model likewise includes override and discernment procedures. Yet neither move makes fruits independently sufficient.

An objection to the original proposition is that "authentication of the subject" may itself be too strong: impressive conduct can coexist with mistaken interpretation. The correction is to say that fruits support the authenticity and seriousness of the transformation, not the infallibility of the subject.

There is also a reverse caution: absence of spectacular virtue does not automatically falsify an experience. Moral development may be gradual, socially obstructed or uneven. Fruits should therefore be assessed longitudinally and proportionately, not used as an instant binary test. Their force lies in consilience with other evidence rather than in a single heroic act.

Therefore moral fruits have genuine but bounded epistemic value. They publicly corroborate sincerity, integration and practical depth; as one strand in a cumulative case, they may support *prima facie* warrant. They neither deductively verify the transcendent object nor resolve conflicts among religious interpretations.

Why this earns marks: Tests both halves of the statement; uses James and Indian discernment; distinguishes utility, authenticity and truth; offers a cumulative reply; gives a calibrated verdict.

Original 4 · 15 marks

Question: Is mystical experience best understood through a common core or through irreducible religious diversity? Discuss with reference to Stace, Zaehner and constructivism.

Model solution: Neither an undifferentiated common core nor absolute diversity is adequate. Mystical reports display recurring phenomenological families, but their objects and logical structures are too different to be treated as one neutral experience with optional labels.

W. T. Stace offers the strongest common-core account. Extrovertive mysticism perceives unity through sensory multiplicity; introvertive mysticism excludes sensory and conceptual content, leaving unitary consciousness. Both display objectivity, blessedness, sacredness, paradox and ineffability. By separating experience from interpretation, Stace explains why Christian, Advaitic and Buddhist descriptions may diverge while sharing experiential depth.

The objection is that "interpretation" may be carrying all inconvenient differences. Identity with Brahman, communion with God and insight into emptiness do not merely attach different names to one relation: one abolishes subject-object duality, another preserves it, and a third may reject any substantial self or ultimate substance.

R. C. Zaehner therefore distinguishes nature, monistic and theistic mysticism. His classification protects the difference between oneness with nature, isolation or identity of soul, and loving union with a personal God. Its weakness is his confessional ranking of theistic mysticism as highest. The classification can be retained while the hierarchy is dropped.

Steven Katz radicalises diversity through constructivism: expectations, language and practices shape the experience itself, so there is no unmediated common event. This explains tradition-specific content but risks making experience merely self-confirming. Robert Forman's Pure Consciousness Event challenges Katz at the contentless limit: if no content is present, what exactly is constructed? Katz may reply that preparation, recognition and memory remain mediated even if the episode is sparse.

A further complication is that "common core" can name more than one claim. It may mean identical phenomenal content, a shared formal structure, or merely recurrent transformative consequences. Evidence against identical content need not eliminate formal similarities such as unity or ineffability. Conversely, agreement about peaceful effects does not establish one metaphysical object. The debate becomes clearer when these levels are not conflated.

Advaita is therefore an especially useful test: its identity-claim may share formal unity with Stace's core while resisting reduction to Zaehner's theistic relation.

A defensible synthesis treats the evidence through **family resemblance**. Stace's extrovertive/introvertive distinction and recurring marks identify cross-cultural patterns; Zaehner correctly preserves monistic/theistic difference; constructivism warns that reports cannot be stripped clean of formation. Mediation need not equal fabrication, but it blocks easy proof of a universal identical core.

Thus mystical experience is neither simply one nor wholly many. It consists of overlapping phenomenological families whose intentional objects and doctrinal structures may remain irreducibly different.

Why this earns marks: Reconstructs all three positions; avoids accepting Zaehner's ranking; uses identity-versus-relation; includes Forman's reply; reaches a discriminating synthesis.

Original 5 · 20 marks

Question: Can religious experience provide *prima facie* justification for belief in a transcendent reality? Evaluate with reference to Swinburne, Alston and Indian claims of direct realisation.

Model solution: Religious experience can provide *prima facie*, defeasible justification for the experiencer, and weaker testimonial support for others, but it does not amount to public proof of a transcendent reality. The defensibility of this claim depends on parity with ordinary epistemic practices and on how seriously religious diversity functions as a defeater.

Richard Swinburne's **principle of credulity** gives the initial argument. If it epistemically seems to a subject that X is present, then, other things being equal, probably X is present. We normally trust perception unless there are specific reasons for doubt; consistently applied, this presumption should not be withdrawn merely because the apparent object is God. His related principle of testimony allows others some reason to trust sincere reports. The warrant remains defeasible by unreliability, conflicting evidence, background improbability or a superior explaining-away account.

William Alston develops a more practice-centred defence in *Perceiving God*. On his theory of appearing, perception is constituted by an object's seeming to present itself, not necessarily by sensory qualities. Some experiences of God can therefore be "M-perceptions" generating M-beliefs. Such beliefs arise within Christian Mystical Practice, a socially established doxastic practice with recognised inputs, outputs and override procedures. Sense perception, memory and induction cannot be non-circularly validated without using those very practices. Since demanding an external proof from religion alone would be asymmetrical, participation in an established mystical practice may be practically rational, and its outputs *prima facie* justified.

Alston's conclusion is deliberately modest. He does not prove that the practice is reliable or that every M-belief is justified all things considered. He shifts the burden to the sceptic to identify a relevant epistemic inferiority rather than merely citing circularity common to all practices.

Indian traditions supply both reinforcement and complication. Advaita calls *aparokṣānubhūti* immediate and self-certifying: Brahman is not perceived as external but recognised as self-luminous consciousness. *Śruti*, reason and *śravaṇa-manana-nididhyāsana* discipline the recognition; the guru and ethical transformation provide tests. Yoga and contemplative traditions also present repeatable training and predicted transformations, approximating expert perception. Yet these claims are not neutral observations. Viśiṣṭādvaita preserves communion with a personal Brahman; Buddhism may report emptiness without a creator; thus the "object" and structure differ.

Three objections are decisive. First, naturalistic accounts attribute experience to neural activity, suggestion, deprivation or wish-fulfilment. This can become a defeater when it demonstrates unreliability, but a neural mechanism alone does not explain away the object: ordinary perception is neurally mediated too. Causal mediation and truth-value are distinct.

Second, religious experiences lack the robust public cross-checking, prediction and agreement of sense perception. Alston replies that traditions do possess discernment and override systems, though they are weaker. This difference justifies a lower confidence level, not necessarily zero warrant.

Third, **diversity** is stronger than neurology. Mutually incompatible practices may each be established and internally coherent. Alston's suggestion that participants may rationally "sit tight" preserves practical rationality but does not resolve truth. Hick's culturally mediated responses to the Real offer one reconciliation, while constructivists contend that traditions shape the experiences themselves. A modest response claims family resemblance, not identical content; however, this weakens inference to any specific transcendent object.

The warrant must therefore be indexed. For the subject, a coherent experience arising within disciplined practice, producing fitting fruits and surviving known defeaters may rationally ground belief. For a hearer, testimony supplies some evidence but competes with plural testimony. For public reason, the episode can be assessed for authenticity and coherence, not converted into demonstration.

Thus religious experience can provide *prima facie* justification, especially personal and practice-relative justification. Swinburne explains the initial presumption; Alston explains rational practice; Indian traditions add non-sensory directness and disciplined replication. But diversity and limited cross-checking prevent the move from defeasible warrant to universally binding proof.

Why this earns marks: Defines the exact epistemic level; reconstructs Swinburne and Alston without overclaiming; supplies Indian parity; ranks naturalism, cross-checking and diversity objections; differentiates subject, testimony and public proof.

Original 6 · 20 marks

Question: "Religious experience is always mediated, but mediation does not necessarily amount to fabrication." Critically evaluate.

Model solution: The statement is defensible if "mediation" means that concepts, practices, language, embodiment and expectations condition how an experience occurs and is recognised, while "fabrication" means that these conditions wholly produce an object with no independent constraint. Religious experience is probably never interpretation-free; it does not follow that it is therefore unreal.

Steven Katz gives the strongest mediation thesis. Against perennialism, he argues that there are no unmediated mystical experiences. A Jewish mystic formed by covenantal theism, an Advaitin trained in *neti neti*, and a Buddhist analysing non-self do not first undergo a neutral event and later attach different descriptions. Their disciplines and categories help structure what is salient and possible within the experience. This explains why reports display detailed doctrinal differences rather than merely different vocabulary.

The thesis gains force from the contrast between **intentional encounter** and **non-dual awareness**. Otto's subject confronts the numinous "wholly other"; theistic mysticism preserves a relation to a personal God; Advaita's *aparokṣānubhūti* sublates the subject-object distinction; Buddhism may deny both a permanent subject and substantial absolute. These are logically different structures. Zaehner's distinction among nature, monistic and theistic mysticism therefore preserves something that Stace's common-core account risks flattening.

Yet mediation does not entail fabrication. Ordinary perception is also shaped by concepts, attention and expert training while remaining answerable to objects. A radiologist sees patterns a novice misses; acquired categories improve access rather than inventing anatomy. Religious disciplines may similarly cultivate capacities and impose correction. Experiences also surprise, resist expectation and transform prior commitments, suggesting that subjects do not simply write the desired script.

William Alston's doxastic-practice account supplies an epistemic form of this reply. Beliefs emerge from socially established practices with inputs and override systems; no practice, including sense perception, is validated from a wholly external standpoint. Religious mediation can therefore be rational without being incorrigible. Indian methods such as *śravaṇa-manana-nididhyāsana*, yogic discipline and guru-guided discernment make explicit that preparation is intended to remove distortion, not manufacture an object.

Robert Forman challenges constructivism through the Pure Consciousness Event, a supposedly contentless state with nothing for concepts to shape. This objection is strongest against a total claim that every experiential feature is doctrinally constructed. Katz can still reply that entry, recognition, memory and interpretation remain mediated. Consequently, Forman may establish a minimally common experiential limit without proving a common metaphysical object.

Radhakrishnan moves further toward a perennial depth. In *The Hindu View of Life*, direct integral intuition of the spiritual Real precedes creeds, which are secondary formulations. This supports inter-religious openness, but risks treating theistic communion and Buddhist emptiness as imperfect expressions of an Advaitic unity. A more defensible version speaks of family resemblance or analogous transformation rather than identical content.

The strongest objection to the statement is sceptical: once there is no unmediated access, how can one distinguish disclosure from tradition-induced projection? Three criteria help without guaranteeing truth: experiential coherence and resistance to wish-fulfilment; public fruits and stable transformation; and communal override procedures capable of rejecting episodes. Cross-traditional convergence adds limited support, while persistent incompatible objects remains a defeater.

The opposite error is neuro-reduction. Showing neural or psychological mediation explains a mechanism, not necessarily away the object. A genuine perception and a hallucination both have neural causes; what matters is whether the causal process is appropriately connected to reality and survives defeaters.

Therefore mediation is unavoidable and philosophically informative: it qualifies claims of pure, universal experience and requires humility about interpretation. But fabrication is a further conclusion demanding evidence of systematic unreliability or unconstrained projection. The best verdict rejects both naïve immediacy and total constructivism: religious experience may be mediated disclosure, though its object receives only defeasible, tradition-situated warrant.

Why this earns marks: Defines the key terms; reconstructs Katz; compares Stace, Zaehner, Forman, Alston and Radhakrishnan; integrates Indian practice; distinguishes causal mechanism from epistemic defeat; finishes with a graded middle position.

Self-scoring and next steps

Diagnostic score (out of 32)	Reading it	What to do next
28-32	the discriminations are secure	practise under time: two 15-markers back to back, 40 minutes total
22-27	content is present, discriminations are soft	re-run the traps for every item missed, then rewrite one model answer from memory
15-21	the layer separation is not yet automatic	re-read the four-layer card and the graded verdict ladder before attempting more questions
below 15	the marks or the object-question are being confused	return to the learning session's Basic block; do not attempt timed answers yet

Trap census by cluster. Of the thirty-two examiner traps in this workbook, seven concern James's grading and scope, five concern the sacred/holy/God module, five concern the Indian structures and the *anirvacanīya* firewall, four concern Alston and the warrant apparatus, four concern the two double-deliverable stems, three concern the

typologies, and four concern the naturalistic and diversity defeaters. A candidate who repeatedly misses one cluster should revise that cluster rather than attempt more mixed practice.

Independence note

Every model answer in Parts 3 and 4 is independent learner practice written to the repository's examiner-grade standard. UPSC does not publish official Mains answers or marking keys, and nothing here should be presented as one. The previous-year stems themselves are reproduced verbatim from the audited 2018-2025 Philosophy of Religion ledger.